

EMPEROR OF FRANCE Born 1769 Died 1821

Napoleon Bonaparte

“Death is nothing, but to live defeated and inglorious is to die daily.”

NAPOLÉON BONAPARTE

The future French emperor Napoleon Bonaparte was born Napoleone Buonaparte, a member of a poor Corsican noble family of Italian origin. A wild island of bandits and vendettas, Corsica became a part of France in 1768, the year before Napoleon's birth. When he was nine years old Napoleon learned French at school so he could attend the military school at Brienne-le-Château in France, but he always spoke with a strong Italian accent. His family was poor enough to have his school fees paid by the state.

That he was an able man was evident at an early stage and, after graduating in 1784, he went on to complete a two-year course at the Royal Military School in Paris in 12 months, proving

notably strong in math, geography, and science. He was commissioned as a sublieutenant of artillery at the age of just 16.

Revolutionary opportunities

On the death of his father in 1785, Napoleon was elected as head of his family, despite not being the eldest son. Corsica remained the focus of his life for some years, to the neglect of his army career. It was only after his family left the island in 1793 because of their pro-French views that Napoleon shifted his ambitions to France. A superb opportunist, he seized the chances for rapid advancement opened up by the French Revolution (see pp.302–03). Appointed a brigadier-general by the Jacobins, a prominent political club of

Portrait of Napoleon

Napoleon carefully controlled his public image, employing only the finest portrait artists of the day to present his desired view of himself to the people. This picture of Napoleon was painted c. 1807 by Hippolyte (Paul) Delaroche.



Peacemaker

On September 30, 1800, Napoleon signed the Treaty of Morte-fontaine, ending a smoldering naval conflict between France and the US, brought about by US reaction to the French Revolution.

Carve up

Drawn in 1805, this caricature by the cartoonist James Gillray demonstrates the greed of great powers. The British prime minister, William Pitt the younger (1759–1806), and Napoleon are carving up the world—the Frenchman seizing a slice of Europe while Britain takes most of the rest.

